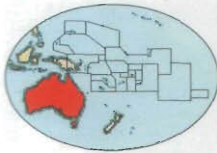




AUSTRALIA



A COUNTRY and at the same time a continent, Australia is an ancient land mass, and the smallest, flattest, and, after Antarctica, the driest continent. It is the world's sixth largest country yet only 18.9 million people live there, mostly along the coast as the centre of the country consists of desert or semi-desert – the outback. Australia consists of six states and two territories. It has strong trade links with Europe, the USA, and Asia and makes significant contributions to international affairs. The population consists of a wide range of ethnic groups, making Australia a truly multicultural society.

Physical features

The centre of Australia is covered by a vast, flat, arid plain called the outback – one of the hottest places on Earth. Around the coast are tropical rainforests, snow-capped mountains, and magnificent beaches.



AUSTRALIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Canberra
AREA	7,617,930 sq km (2,941,283 sq miles)
POPULATION	18,900,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	English
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Australian dollar
LIFE EXPECTANCY	79 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	400
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%

Great Barrier Reef

Green Island forms part of the Great Barrier Reef, which stretches 2,000 km (1,243 miles) along the northeast coast of Australia. Its coral is formed by layer upon layer of tiny anemone-like creatures, making it the largest living thing on Earth. Thousands of tourists flock to see it each year, attracted by the clear, warm waters and more than 1,500 species of fish. Recent fears that divers and swimmers may be damaging the reef have led to it becoming a protected World Heritage Area.



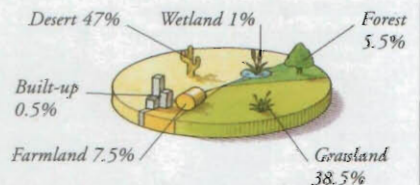
Uluru (Ayers Rock)

This giant block of red sandstone that rises from the desert is more than 2.4 km (1.5 miles) long. Once known as Ayers Rock, Uluru, meaning "great pebble", is the original name given to it by the Aboriginal people, who regard it as sacred.



Great Dividing Range

The Great Dividing Range is a series of high plateaus and low mountains that extends down the east of Australia. It shields the arid interior of the country from the rain-bearing clouds that blow in from the Pacific Ocean. In winter, snow covers the higher peaks, and people can ski there.



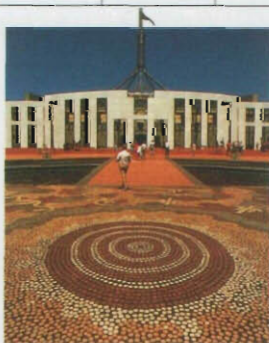
Land use

Most of Australia's interior is inhospitable desert. Sheep and cattle are reared in the east and north of the country, and wheat is grown in the fertile southwest and southeast. Australia has rich mineral deposits, many of which are in the barren interior.



Canberra

Founded in the early 20th century, Australia's capital, Canberra, is home to about 300,000 people. It is primarily a centre for government and has few industries. Official buildings include Parliament House, the Australian National University, the National Library, and the National Gallery.



Parliament House

Climate

Most people live in the temperate zones that occur within 400 km (249 miles) of the coast in the east and southeast, and around Perth in the west. The interior, west, and south are arid. The north is hot, humid, and tropical.

